CHAPTER 10

Trigonometry: circle, radians and related angles

Chapter path

Objectives. Convert from degrees to radians; place points; calculate standard sines and cosines; use the symmetries of the circle.
Prerequisites. Circle, Pythagoras, cosine and sine in a right triangle, symmetries, fractions.
Yearly reference point. 2–11 March: 8 hours

Diagnostic: six questions, 10 minutes

Answer without consulting the lesson. Mark the questions for which help is needed. This diagnostic is not graded.

1. Perimeter of a circle of radius 1?
2. How many degrees is a quarter turn?
3. Calculate $\sqrt{\frac{1}{2}}$.
4. What are the x- and y-coordinates of the reflection of $(a; b)$ in the x-axis?
5. Simplify $\frac{5\pi}{3} - 2\pi$.
6. In a right triangle, opposite side 3 and hypotenuse 5: sine?

After the diagnostic. Revisit the flagged topics with the teacher; redo a similar question, then explain the rule used.

Speaking and logic. Present an equality of related angles, naming the symmetry that justifies it; explain what a radian measures.

Investigate before formalising

Construct, without a protractor, a point at angle $\frac{\pi}{3}$ then a point at angle $\frac{\pi}{4}$. Justify the exact values of their coordinates from the figures.

Organisation. Individual investigation 5 min, comparison in pairs 5 min, class discussion 5 min. Keep a record of one attempt, even an unfinished one. A conjecture must then be justified.

10.1 Measuring an angle in radians

Definition and results

The unit circle is the circle with centre O and radius 1, oriented anticlockwise. One radian corresponds to an arc of length 1 on this circle. A full turn is 2π radians, a half turn π. On a circle of radius r, an arc length is $r\theta$ for a positive angle θ expressed in radians.

Status and justification. Definitions and proportionality between central angle and arc length. The conversion is $180° = \pi$ radians; we multiply degrees by $\frac{\pi}{180}$.

Worked example. $60° = \frac{\pi}{3}$; $\frac{3\pi}{2} = 270°$. An angle of $\frac{\pi}{3}$ on a circle of radius 6 cm gives an arc of 2π cm.

Watch out

The length of an arc is not that of the chord. In trigonometric calculations, check the degree or radian mode of the tool.

Immediate application. Convert 45°, 120°; give the arc for radius 2 m and angle $\frac{3\pi}{4}$.

10.2 Wrapping and the image of a real number

Definition and results

To each real number x corresponds a point M of the circle, obtained by an oriented path of length x starting from I(1;0). Two real numbers have the same image if their difference is an integer multiple of 2π. A negative number indicates a path in the clockwise direction.

Status and justification. Adding or removing a whole number of turns keeps the end point. Conversely, returning to the same point requires a whole number of turns.

Worked example. $\frac{13\pi}{3} = 4\pi + \frac{\pi}{3}$ has the same image as $\frac{\pi}{3}$. $-\frac{\pi}{2}$ has the same image as $\frac{3\pi}{2}$: the point $(0;-1)$.

Watch out

Adding π gives the opposite point, not the same point.

Immediate application. Place the images of $\frac{7\pi}{2}$ and $-\frac{5\pi}{3}$ by reducing them to within one turn.

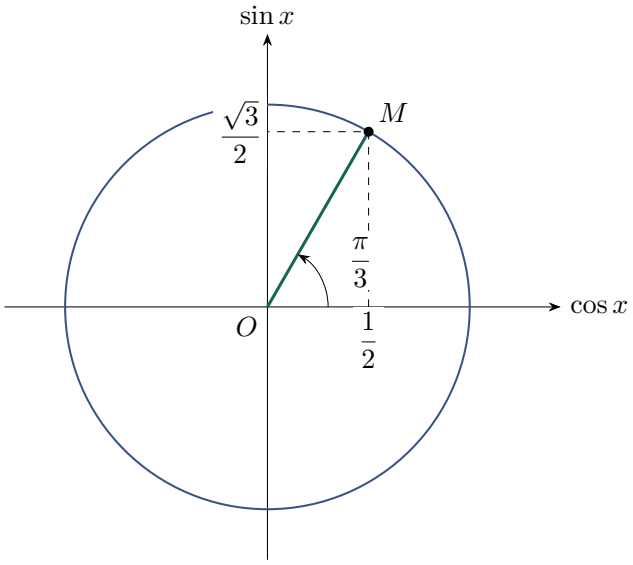
10.3 Sine, cosine and standard values

Definition and results

If M is the image of x, $M = (\cos x; \sin x)$. So $-1 \leq \cos x, \sin x \leq 1$ and $\cos^2 x + \sin^2 x = 1$. For $x = 0, \frac{\pi}{6}, \frac{\pi}{4}, \frac{\pi}{3}, \frac{\pi}{2}$, the cosines are $1, \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}, \frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}, \frac{1}{2}, 0$ and the sines $0, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}, \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}, 1$.

Status and justification. At $\frac{\pi}{4}$, the two coordinates are equal and positive; Pythagoras gives $2a^2 = 1$, so $a = \frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}$. An equilateral triangle of side 1, cut by its altitude, has half-base $\frac{1}{2}$ and height $\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}$: $\cos(\frac{\pi}{3}) = \frac{1}{2}$, $\sin(\frac{\pi}{3}) = \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}$. The complementary angle gives $\frac{\pi}{6}$.

Worked example. The point at angle $\frac{\pi}{3}$ is $(\frac{1}{2}; \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2})$. The scalar product of two unit vectors forming this angle equals its cosine, so $\frac{1}{2}$. The geometry chapters thus connect to the circle.



For the angle $\frac{\pi}{3}$, the projections of M give its cosine and sine directly. The fractions are placed outside the lines of the drawing.

Watch out

The cosine is the x-coordinate, the sine the y-coordinate. The identity gives an absolute value: the quadrant determines the sign.

Immediate application. If $\cos x = \frac{3}{5}$ and the image of x is in the fourth quadrant, give $\sin x$.

10.4 Related angles and symmetries

Definition and results

The symmetries of the circle give $\cos(-x) = \cos x$, $\sin(-x) = -\sin x$; $\cos(\pi - x) = -\cos x$, $\sin(\pi - x) = \sin x$; $\cos(\pi + x) = -\cos x$, $\sin(\pi + x) = -\sin x$. Adding $2k\pi$, k an integer, changes neither sine nor cosine.

Status and justification. Each equality can be read from the coordinates of the symmetric points: horizontal axis for $-x$, vertical axis for $\pi - x$, centre O for $\pi + x$. This is not a catalogue without justification.

Worked example. $\cos(\frac{5\pi}{6}) = -\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}$, $\sin(\frac{5\pi}{6}) = \frac{1}{2}$ by symmetry from $\frac{\pi}{6}$. $\cos(-\frac{\pi}{4}) = \frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}$, $\sin(-\frac{\pi}{4}) = -\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}$.

Watch out

Two angles with the same cosine do not necessarily have the same sine. Reduce the angle, then read the signs.

Immediate application. Calculate the two coordinates of the images of $\frac{4\pi}{3}$ and $\frac{7\pi}{4}$.

10.5 Approximating pi and putting it to use

Definition and results

A regular inscribed polygon with n sides in the unit circle has half-perimeter $n\sin(\frac{\pi}{n})$; a circumscribed polygon has half-perimeter $n\tan(\frac{\pi}{n})$, with $\tan\theta = \frac{\sin\theta}{\cos}\theta$ here. Archimedes' method doubles the number of sides and calculates the new lengths by Pythagoras, without knowing pi in advance.

Status and justification. The inscribed perimeter is less than that of the circle and the circumscribed one greater: geometric bounds accepted. If c is the chord of one side, let $h = \sqrt{1 - \frac{c^2}{4}}$; the chord of the half-angle is $\frac{c}{\sqrt{2(1+h)}}$. This formula comes from Pythagoras and avoids a subtraction of nearby real numbers.

Worked example. For the inscribed hexagon, c=1 and half-perimeter 3. The circumscribed one gives $2\sqrt{3} \approx 3.4641$. By doubling the sides, we tighten the bounds. The supplied program starts from n=6 and c=1.

Watch out

Using a sine function directly with pi already known would check a calculation, but would not construct an approximation independent of pi.

Immediate application. For n=6 and c=1, calculate the new chord after doubling.

Exercise path

Start with exercises 1 and 2. Then choose one of exercises 3 or 4 and do it without help. Exercises 5 to 7 are a reserve for transfer, investigation or programming: the teacher designates one. Exercise 8 is revisited after a delay.

Exercise 10.1 – Converting and measuring

We use the unit circle to measure angles in radians.

1. Convert $150°$ and $-90°$ to radians, showing the conversion factor.
2. A circular sector has radius 4 cm and an angle of $\dfrac{\pi}{3}$ radians. Calculate the exact length of its arc.
3. Explain why an angle measure can be negative while a geometric arc length is positive.

Exercise 10.2 – Reducing angles

Consider the real numbers $\dfrac{17\pi}{6}$, $-\dfrac{7\pi}{4}$ and 5π.

1. For each, determine a representative in $[0;2\pi[$ having the same image on the unit circle. Show the number of turns added or removed.
2. Place the three images on a circle and identify them by the starting real numbers.

Exercise 10.3 – Exact values

We look for the exact values of the cosine and sine of $\dfrac{2\pi}{3}$, $-\dfrac{\pi}{6}$ and $\dfrac{5\pi}{4}$.

1. Place the three images on the unit circle. For each, state the expected sign of its two coordinates.
2. Calculate the exact values using a standard angle and a symmetry. Present the answer in a table: angle, cosine, sine.

Exercise 10.4 – Recovering the sign

A real number x satisfies $\sin x = \dfrac{5}{13}$. Its image on the unit circle lies in the second quadrant, that is to the left of the y-axis and above the x-axis.

1. Determine the exact value of $\cos x$. Justify both its absolute value and its sign.
2. Explain why the value of $\sin x$ alone would not have been enough to choose the sign of $\cos x$.

Exercise 10.5 – A wheel

A wheel of radius 0.30 m rolls on horizontal ground without slipping. It turns through an angle of $\dfrac{5\pi}{3}$ radians. We look for the distance travelled by its axle in the direction of motion.

1. Calculate this distance in exact form, explaining the link with the arc length unrolled.
2. Explain why the length of a chord of the circle must not be used. Is the path of a point fixed on the rim of the wheel, seen from the ground, the same as that of the axle?

Exercise 10.6 – Chord and scalar product

On the unit circle with centre O, the point A is the image of 0 and the point B that of $\dfrac{2\pi}{3}$.

1. Determine the exact coordinates of A and B, then calculate the length AB.
2. Recover this length by applying the Al-Kashi relation to the triangle OAB. State the lengths and the angle used.

Exercise 10.7 – Reading an equation on the circle

We look for the real numbers x in the interval $[0; 2\pi[$ whose image on the unit circle has x-coordinate $\dfrac{1}{2}$.

1. Translate the condition on the x-coordinate into an equation involving $\cos x$.
2. Draw the corresponding vertical line on a circle, mark its intersections and give the two solutions. Check that they belong to the interval required.

Exercise 10.8 – Delayed review

Consider the angle of measure $\dfrac{25\pi}{4}$ radians. The answers must be exact, with no decimal approximation.

1. Reduce this angle, showing a whole number of complete turns.
2. Deduce its cosine and sine. Justify the values using the unit circle.

Homework. Do only the task designated at the end of the session, in the dated progression: 10–20 min at most. The exercises depend on the topics already studied, so some questions are deferred. Revisit exercise 8 one week after the chapter (10 min). If the allotted time is exceeded, note the difficulty and bring your attempts; do not pile up the whole reserve.

To do in the CQFD textbook

These exercises are done in your textbook. The progression indicates the session; they replace the homework planned for that day (10 to 20 minutes in total).

CQFD, exercise 32 p. 220, questions a and b. Use the exact value supplied and the related angles, without a calculator.

CQFD, exercise 39 p. 220, questions 1, 2, 3 and 5. Do the four calculation and circle-reading questions; justify the answers on your paper.

MCQ 1: understand and choose

Five single-answer questions for practice. Choose one answer per question; then explain one distractor. This chapter format does not reproduce the official EAM format.

1. $180°$ equals
   - A. 2π
   - B. π
   - C. $\frac{\pi}{2}$
   - D. 1
2. $\cos(\frac{\pi}{3}) =$
   - A. $\frac{1}{2}$
   - B. $\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}$
   - C. 0
   - D. 1
3. $\sin(-\frac{\pi}{2}) =$
   - A. 1
   - B. 0
   - C. $\frac{1}{2}$
   - D. -1
4. $\cos^2 x + \sin^2 x =$
   - A. 0
   - B. 2
   - C. 1
   - D. x
5. The same point corresponds to angles differing by
   - A. π
   - B. $2k\pi$, k an integer
   - C. $\frac{\pi}{2}$
   - D. 1

MCQ 2: understand and choose

Five single-answer questions for practice. Choose one answer per question; then explain one distractor. This chapter format does not reproduce the official EAM format.

1. $\cos(\pi - x) =$
   - A. $\cos x$
   - B. $\sin x$
   - C. $-\cos x$
   - D. $-\sin x$
2. $\sin(\frac{\pi}{4}) =$
   - A. $\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}$
   - B. $\frac{1}{2}$
   - C. $\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}$
   - D. $\sqrt{2}$
3. Image of $\frac{3\pi}{2}$:
   - A. $(1;0)$
   - B. $(-1;0)$
   - C. $(0;1)$
   - D. $(0;-1)$
4. Arc of radius 3 and angle 2 radians: length
   - A. $\frac{2}{3}$
   - B. 6
   - C. $\frac{3}{2}$
   - D. 6π
5. Interior of the second quadrant: sign of the cosine
   - A. positive
   - B. zero everywhere
   - C. negative
   - D. cannot be determined

True or false? Justify.

1. $\cos(-x) = -\cos x$ for all x.
2. $\sin(x + 2\pi) = \sin x$.
3. The value of $\sin x$ always determines $\cos x$.

Self-assessment

I reduce angles by complete turns; I read cosine and sine in the right order; I justify the signs; I keep the exact values.
For each objective, indicate: achieved without help; achieved with help; to be reworked. Write one example and one mistake to avoid.